or Gram Development Officer can do anything about it … Under PM Awas Yojana, the list of those 136 people who have been sanctioned houses in the village this year based on the survey report [109 in the previous year] has been hung up on a board in the Gram Sabha Sachivalaya [Village Council Secretariat]. Check your names there. For those who are left out … it is for them that this camp is being organised tomorrow so everyone eligible gets the benefit of these schemes.' Yogi then asked the district officer to read out the full list for the crowd to verify.

A bespectacled and moustachioed bureaucrat now took the mike and started intoning, somewhat surreally, from the list of those being given money for government housing. 'The people whose dreams have been fulfilled with this allotment are … 1. Pramod Bharat, Scheduled Caste 2. Laxman Bhagwati, Scheduled Caste …' and so on.

This village meeting in Pratapgarh, held in April 2018, exactly a year after Yogi Adityanath became the chief minister of UP following a landslide election win for the BJP, was the first in a new 'chaupal', or village gathering, initiative he started. It targeted political outreach on the government's social-welfare programmes ahead of the 2019 general elections. The immediate aim was to build a layer of political mobilisation and public accountability around government spending, directly linking it to the BJP's efforts. When, for example, villagers complained that they had only received ₹10,000 of the ₹12,000 that Yogi said they were entitled to under the Swachh Bharat scheme, he explained, 'Please note this and understand: you are to get Rs 10,000 in the first tranche for each personal toilet. The remaining Rs 2,000 comes after its geotagging and verification has been done.' He added, 'I request you all to get full information on government schemes. Accusations and counter-accusations won't solve anything … and if any corrupt officers ask any labharthee for money, we have arranged that not only will they be jailed and an FIR filed, their property will be confiscated, because people's exploitation can only prosper where people don't have enough knowledge of government schemes and people are not aware enough, which in turn encourages corrupt elements.'